

# Verb agreement

THE NUMBER OF THE SUBJECT DICTATES THE NUMBER OF THE VERB.

Like nouns and pronouns, a verb can be singular or plural in number, but it must match the subject to which it relates. Sometimes it's hard to know whether a noun is singular or plural, leading to errors in verb agreement.

## SEE ALSO

◀ 22–23 Nouns

◀ 24–25 Plurals

◀ 34–35 Pronouns

◀ 36–37 Number and gender

◀ 38–39 Verbs

◀ 42–43 Simple tenses

Prepositions

60–61 ▶

## Singular or plural?

The key to correct verb agreement is to follow this simple rule: If the subject is singular, the verb must be singular; if the subject is plural, the verb must also be plural.

The **competitors** **have** arrived,  
and the **Mighty Musclemen**  
**contest** **is** about to start.

subject → The subject is plural so the verb must be plural.  
subject → The subject is singular so the verb must be singular.

• Some nouns sound plural but are actually treated as **singular**. These include **mathematics** and **politics**, as well as **proper nouns** such as *United States* or *Philippines*.

## Identifying the subject

One problem occurs when the wrong word is identified as the subject. This often happens when the subject and verb are separated by a prepositional phrase. When the prepositional phrase is removed from the sentence, it becomes clear which noun or pronoun is the true subject.

The box **of extra weights** **are** ready. ❌

↑ This is a prepositional phrase, made up of the preposition *of*, the adjective *extra*, and the noun *weights*.

The **box** **are** ready. ❌

↑ The prepositional phrase has been removed from the sentence, so it is now clear that the subject (*box*) is singular.

The **box** **is** ready. ✅

↑ The subject is singular, so the singular verb form *is* is used.

The box **of extra weights** **is** ready. ✅

↑ The prepositional phrase has been put back into the sentence, and the verb now agrees with the subject.

## Collective nouns

Most collective nouns (for example, *class* or *crowd*) are singular words, because they can be made plural (*classes*, *crowds*). However, some collective nouns, including *team*, *staff*, and *couple*, can be singular or plural. A good general rule to follow is to consider whether the noun is acting as a unit or whether the noun is made up of individuals acting in different ways.

My **team** **has** won.

↑ Here, the team represents a unit, so the singular form of the verb is used.

The **team** **are** divided in their feelings.

↑ Here, the individual members of the team are acting in different ways, so the plural form of the verb is used.